

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN BURUNDI

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Burundi is a small, mountainous, extraordinarily densely populated Great Lakes nation, among the poorest on earth, whose western edge is the shore of **Lake Tanganyika** — one of the world's largest, deepest, and most biodiverse lakes, and the lifeline of the nation's millions. Its steep, deforested slopes wash their soil into that lake with every rain, and the sediment, overfishing, and pollution are slowly degrading it. Joined to that is a second great question: the vast **Musongati nickel deposit**, whose development promises revenue a desperately poor country badly needs, yet threatens its water and land. Burundi is a land of green, over-farmed hills, of the lake and its fisheries, of a rapidly growing rural population on too little land, and of a governance that is authoritarian-leaning and a civic space that is narrowed. There is no landmark community victory to point to. But the shared lake and the scrutiny of the nickel give real ground.

A community in Burundi facing a harmful project — a nickel mine threatening the water and land, a development degrading the lake — works with real, if constrained, tools, kept careful and watershed-grounded. A major project like the Musongati mine is supposed to undergo an **environmental and social impact assessment** — a gate that can be pressed where it is skipped or defective. The mine can be scrutinised against **environmental, water, and governance standards**, and against the **international standards and financiers** a large nickel project answers to. The **regional framework for Lake Tanganyika** — the shared convention and authority of the riparian states — is a distinctive transboundary lever: harm to a lake four nations depend on is not Burundi's alone to permit. The **courts and functioning institutions** can be reached where it is safe. And the **technical, regional, and international channels** carry the case where the state is fraught. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The state is semi-closed and authoritarian-leaning, and the civic space constrained, so the work must be careful, within-system, and strictly neutral on the politics and the ethnic history. The nickel is revenue a desperately poor country needs, so it must be scrutinised, not simply opposed. And the deforestation and erosion that harm the lake are bound up with poverty and density — so justice forbids mere bans, and the poor who farm the hills to survive must never be met with repression. There is no landmark victory to point to. So the work must protect everyone involved, stay watershed-grounded and apolitical, and aim at the harm scrutinised and restrained — the mine assessed, the lake's regional framework invoked, the pollution documented — not an open defeat of a needed development. Above all, protect the people, and never punish the poor.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot simply oppose a nickel deposit a poor country needs, nor safely mount open confrontation in a semi-closed state, nor justly ban the poor from the hills they farm to live. What you can do is scrutinise the harm: force the mine through a real assessment, hold it to environmental and governance standards, invoke the shared Lake Tanganyika framework four nations answer to, document the harm to the lake, and work through the technical, regional, and international channels — carefully, watershed-grounded, apolitical, and protecting everyone.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Burundi is a poor, fragile, constrained setting, and honesty about that is the first discipline. This is not a fight you win by opposing a needed development or by banning the poor, nor by open confrontation with a semi-closed state. It is a careful, within-system, watershed-grounded effort whose realistic prize is the harm scrutinised and restrained — a mine assessed and conditioned, the lake's framework invoked, the pollution pressed — not an open stop. Frame everything around the lake and the environment, never the politics, and protect everyone involved.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power rests with an authoritarian-leaning state in a poor, fragile nation with a narrowed civic space. But the decisions a careful effort can reach run through the constrained channels that function: the **environment and mining authorities and their assessment procedures**, the **regional Lake Tanganyika framework and authority** the riparian states share, the **international standards and financiers** behind a large project, the **courts where safe**, and the **technical and community channels**. Map who decides, and where it is safe to act, before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A large mine or development needs an environmental and social impact assessment, and — for the lake — must reckon with the shared regional framework. The assessment is the point of entry, where a documented case can press for a proper process, conditions, or the standards the law and the framework require. Beyond it lie the regional Lake Tanganyika bodies, the international financiers' standards, and the courts where safe. Enter always where it is safe, and strictly around the environment.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the lake: what sediment, pollution, or harm the project brings to Lake Tanganyika, and what the shared regional framework requires. Follow the nickel: which company and financiers stand behind Musongati, and what environmental, water, and governance standards they answer to. Follow the assessment: whether a proper environmental and social impact study was done, and where it fell short. The leverage lies in the assessment, the standards, and the shared lake's regional framework.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Oversight is constrained, but the environment and mining authorities' assessment procedures, the regional Lake Tanganyika framework and authority, the international financiers and their standards, the courts where safe, and the technical and regional networks are the channels a careful case engages — holding each, where safe, to what the law, the standards, and the framework require.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Burundian effort easily stops a needed development, and honesty requires saying so — the state is constrained and the nickel is revenue. But the assessment, the standards, and above all the shared lake's regional framework are real. The single most decisive move is **grounding the case in the assessment and the Lake Tanganyika framework**, because it is technical, watershed-grounded, and reaches beyond one state to the four that share the lake — and because it stays clear of the politics that would endanger it. The assessment is the sharpest gate; the environmental and governance standards the strongest handle; the

regional framework the distinctive, transboundary lever. The realistic prize is a mine assessed and conditioned, the lake's framework invoked, the pollution documented and pressed — pursued safely, and never against the poor.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the sediment and pollution to the lake, the mine's threat to water and land, the erosion. **What does it owe?** — an assessment, environmental and water standards, the shared lake's regional obligations. **Who stands behind it?** — the company, the financiers, and the standards they answer to. **Which channel is safe?** — the assessment, the regional framework, the international bodies, the courts where safe. **How is everyone kept safe, and the poor not punished?** — the overriding questions, answered by staying watershed-grounded and apolitical and contesting the harm, not the poor. Pick the harm where the assessment or the lake framework offers the clearest, safest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, watershed-grounded. **Layer one: the harm to the lake** — the sediment, pollution, or mine footprint documented, and the science of the lake's fragility. **Layer two: the standard and the framework** — what assessment, environmental, water, and governance standards the project owes, and what the shared Lake Tanganyika framework requires, and where they were skipped. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which functioning institution, regional body, or international financier to reach, and the absolute discipline of staying apolitical, protecting everyone, and never targeting the poor. A case built on the lake's science and the shared framework — technical and apolitical — is one the institutions and the region must answer.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **lake record**: the sediment, pollution, and fisheries data, the science of Lake Tanganyika's fragility, the harm the project brings. Gather the **standard record**: the assessment, the environmental, water, and governance standards, the Lake Tanganyika convention and authority's requirements. Gather the **project record**: the company, the financiers, and the international standards they answer to. Gather the **channel record**: the environment and mining authorities, the regional framework bodies, the international partners, the courts where safe. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm the case stays watershed-grounded and apolitical, protects everyone, and never targets the poor who farm to live.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE COMMUNITY, REGIONAL & INTERNATIONAL COALITION

Build the coalition carefully and only where it is safe: the **affected lake and hill communities**, whose water and land are at stake; the **technical and scientific bodies** that hold the lake's case; the **regional Lake Tanganyika framework and the other riparian states**, who share the stake; and the **international partners and financiers' watchdogs** who can reach the project's standards. Frame the effort strictly around the lake and the environment, never the politics or the ethnic history; involve no one who could be endangered; and never turn the fight against the poor who farm the hills to survive — win them as allies, with alternatives, not adversaries.

STEP 4: ASSESSMENT, STANDARDS & THE LAKE FRAMEWORK — CONTESTING THE HARM CAREFULLY

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained, the nickel is needed, and the work must be careful, watershed-grounded, and safe.

The Assessment and the Standards

A large mine or development is supposed to undergo an **environmental and social impact assessment**, and can be held to **environmental, water, and governance standards** — and, for a project like Musongati, to the **international standards its financiers answer to**. Where the assessment is skipped or defective, or the standards unmet, a documented case can press for a proper process and real conditions.

The Lake Tanganyika Regional Framework

The distinctive Burundian lever is the **shared regional framework for Lake Tanganyika** — the convention and authority of the four riparian states. Harm to a lake that four nations depend on is not Burundi's alone to permit, and the shared framework gives a community and its regional allies a transboundary lever the single state cannot simply brush aside.

The Courts and International Channels

The **courts and functioning institutions**, where safe, and the **regional and international channels** add reach. Pursued together — the assessment and standards, the shared lake framework, and the international channels — these levers contest the harm carefully and win real scrutiny and conditions, while protecting everyone and never punishing the poor.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always around the lake. **For the environment and mining authorities**: here is a project that skipped or failed the assessment and standards your law requires, with the harm to the lake. **For the regional Lake Tanganyika bodies**: here is harm to the shared lake your framework exists to prevent. **For the international financiers**: here is a project that fails the standards you answer to. **For the community**: here is the lake and the water we all depend on, and the alternatives that spare both livelihood and lake. **The golden rule**: keep everything watershed-grounded and apolitical, contest the harm and never the poor, and protect everyone — that is the safe and effective register here.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with care in a constrained state. Frame the story strictly around the **lake and the environment**: the defence of Lake Tanganyika, the water of millions, against sediment, pollution, and an unscrutinised mine — never the politics or the ethnic history. Carry it through the technical and scientific press, the regional Lake Tanganyika networks, and the international environmental outlets. A few cautions govern everything: keep it strictly to the lake and environment; never touch the politics; protect everyone; never target the poor; and let the lake's science and the shared framework carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, watershed-grounded, apolitical, and protective of everyone.

8A — To the environment authority: identify the project, the harm to the lake, and the assessment or standards it skipped, and request a proper assessment and conditions.

8B — To the mining authority: set out the environmental, water, and governance standards the nickel project must meet, and request them.

8C — To the Lake Tanganyika regional framework/authority: connect the harm to the shared lake and request the framework's engagement.

8D — To an international financier: present the harm and ask how the financing meets the institution's standards.

8E — To a technical or scientific body: request the evidence on the lake's fragility and the project's harm.

8F — To a regional or international environmental body: describe the harm to the shared lake and request attention.

8G — To the affected community: set out the shared stake in the lake and the alternatives, and organise safely.

8H — To the international public: summarise the lake-and-water case and ask for support, without exposing anyone or targeting the poor.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: document the harm to the lake or the mine's threat; write the one-page case (the harm, the assessment or standard skipped, the shared framework); identify the safest channel — usually the environment authority or the regional Lake Tanganyika framework. **The fastest-moving levers:** the assessment gate, the environmental and governance standards, and the shared lake framework.

Emergency coalition-building: reach the affected community, a technical ally, and the regional framework first — safely and apolitically. Throughout, protect everyone and never target the poor.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted by a semi-closed state, a needed nickel deposit, and a narrowed civic space. Recognise it and adjust the aim — not a defeat of the development, but the harm scrutinised and restrained. Lean on the levers the tilt cannot easily reach: the assessment, the international financiers' standards, and above all the shared Lake Tanganyika framework that binds four states. And accept the honest limits — the mine may proceed, the space is narrow — while still winning the assessment, the conditions, and the lake's protection the framework requires, and protecting everyone.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary tilt from capture — the nickel steered to insiders, assessments waved through, standards ignored. Where capture appears, respond only through the **safe channels**: the assessment, the international financiers' standards, the regional framework, the courts where safe. Never through anything political or the ethnic history. **On safety and care:** this note matters here. Burundi is a poor, semi-closed, authoritarian-leaning state with a constrained civic space. Favour the community, technical, regional-framework, and international channels over open confrontation; protect those involved; frame the work strictly around the lake, the forests, and the environment, never the politics or the ethnic history; never

punish the poor who farm the hills; and handle the government and the wider context factually and neutrally. Care is the first rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, watershed-grounded and only where safe. The documented harm feeds the assessment challenge, the standards case, and the regional-framework appeal at once; the community, technical, and regional coalition organises carefully alongside; the media carries the lake frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm to the lake and the standards owed, safely; **months two to six**, press the assessment, the standards, the financiers, and the regional framework; **beyond**, secure the conditions and the lake's protection, and defend them. The core discipline: lake-grounded, apolitical, worked through what functions, never against the poor, and absolute in protecting everyone.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Burundi is a poor, fragile, constrained ground, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a needed development can simply be defeated, or that the space is open, or that a landmark victory exists — none of that is true, and justice forbids banning the poor who farm to live. What it claims is narrower and real: that a project like Musongati is supposed to undergo an assessment a documented case can press; that it can be held to environmental, water, and governance standards, and to the standards its international financiers answer to; and that harm to Lake Tanganyika is not Burundi's alone to permit, because four nations share the lake and its regional framework. The levers are constrained, the work careful, watershed-grounded, and apolitical, and the prize is the harm scrutinised and restrained — a mine assessed and conditioned, the lake's framework invoked, the pollution pressed — not an open stop. But in a poor, dense, semi-closed Great Lakes nation, that careful, lake-grounded effort — worked through what functions, protecting everyone, and never punishing the poor — is not a lesser ambition. It is the responsible and effective one, and it can genuinely defend the great lake on which the nation depends.